Philosophy 101
Introduction to Philosophy
Fall 2026

Section 02 (CRN 10809)
Monday, Wednesday, Friday 10-10:50 am
Education Center 111

Instructor: Andrew Garnar
Alignment: Lawful Good
Office: 16 Glebe St. #300
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Student hours: Monday 12:00-12:50 pm, 2:00-2:50 pm; Wednesday 12:00-12:50 pm, 2:00-2:50 pm; and by appointment

Required texts:

On-line readings available through OAKS

Required materials:

A writing implement and paper to write on
Access to a good, unabridged dictionary and a regular news source

Course description

This course will introduce you to philosophy through exploring important debates in philosophy. Some of these topics will include: whether values are relative; can knowledge be objective; is it reasonable to believe in God based on faith; does wealth inequality violate our ideals of equality and justice; what is the nature of consciousness? We investigate these questions through reading a wide selection of classic and contemporary philosophers. Through class discussions and writing assignments, students will develop and defend their own views.

Course Objectives

• Students will read and analyze influential arguments from philosophy about metaphysical and epistemological issues such as the existence of God, the reality of the external world and the role of sense experience in knowledge.
• Students will read and analyze some influential arguments from philosophy about ethics, including whether values are relative and the nature of moral responsibility.

General Education Student Learning Outcome: Critical Thinking

Students conduct or provide analyses or interpretations to substantiate claims. More specifically, students will be able to:

- Identify or frame a claim or assumption requiring evidence or support.
- Use appropriate evidence to support an analysis or claim.
- Reach a clear and well-supported conclusion.

This outcome will be assessed in Exam 2.

Tentative reading schedule and due dates

August	17	Introductions
	19	Schneider “If a Chatbot Tells You…”
	21	Plato *Meno* selection
	24	Benedict “A Defense of Ethical Relativism”
	26	Rachels “The Challenge of Cultural Relativism”
	28	Craig and Sinnot-Armstrong selections
	31	Aquinas, Selections
September	2	Clifford “The Ethics of Belief” (Section I)
	4	Clifford “The Ethics of Belief” (Sections II, III)
	7	James “The Will to Believe” (Sections I, IV, VII, VIII)
	9	James “The Will to Believe” (Sections IX, X)
	11	Religious belief wrap-up
	14	**Exam 1**
	16	Descartes “Meditations on First Philosophy: Mediation II”
	18	Descartes “Meditations on First Philosophy: Mediation IV”
	21	Descartes “Meditations on First Philosophy: Mediation VI”
	23	Descartes “Meditations on First Philosophy: Mediation VI”
	25	Descartes wrap up
	28	Hume selections [Book 1, Part 1, Section 1, 2; Part 3, Section 1, 2, 4]
	30	Hume selections [Book 1, Part 3, Sections 5, 6, 7, 10]
October	2	Hume selections [Book 1, Part 3, Sections 14]
	5	Hume selections [Book 1, Part 4, Section 7]

	7	Rationalism and empiricism wrap-up
	9	Churchland “A neurophilosophical slant on consciousness research”
	12	**Fall break**
	14	Churchland “A neurophilosophical slant on consciousness research” Mørch “Is Matter Conscious?”
	16	Mørch “Is Matter Conscious?”
	19	TBA
	21	TBA
	23	Philosophy of mind wrap-up
	26	**Exam 2**
	28	Distributive justice introduction
	30	Rawls, “A Theory of Justice” (pages 3-6; 10-15)
November	2	Rawls, “A Theory of Justice” (pages 15-19; 52-56)
	4	Nozick, “Distributive Justice” (pages 149-153, 160-164)
	6	Nozick, “Distributive Justice” (pages 167-174)
	9	Wareham “African Distributive Justice”
	11	Wareham “African Distributive Justice”
	13	Distributive justice wrap-up
	16	Nussbaum, “Humanities and Human Capabilities”
	18	Nussbaum, “Humanities and Human Capabilities” Sartre, “Existentialism is a Humanism”
	20	Sartre, “Existentialism is a Humanism”
	23	Kant “What is Enlightenment?”
	25	**Thanksgiving Break**
	27	**Thanksgiving Break**
	30	Conclusions
December	7	**Final Exam 10:30 am-12:30 pm**

Note: this reading schedule is tentative. When changes are made, they will be posted on OAKS.

Assignments

Exam 1	200
Exam 2	200
Final Exam	300
Activities	150
Class participation	150
Total	**1000 points**

Exams 1 and 2

You will have 2 50-minute exams. Each exam will consist of one or more essay questions covering material from the course.

Final Exam

You will have a final exam which consist of 3 essay questions covering material from the course.

Activities

There will be activities in class related to the material discussed that day. Possible activities include: quizzes on the reading, in-class debates, group activities, and reflective writing. There will be a total of 36 activities, the last 6 will be extra credit. Each activity is worth 5 points. See OAKS for how these will be assessed and what days we will not have them.

Class participation

Each student is expected to participate on a regular basis. The minimum expectation is 2 substantive contributions to the class discussion per week. See OAKS for how this will be assessed.

Grading Scale

A = 93.0-100	C= 73.0-76.9
A- = 90.0-92.9	C- = 70.0-72.9
B+ = 87.0-89.9	D+ = 67.0-69.9
B = 83.0-86.9	D = 63.0-66.9
B- = 80.0-82.9	D- = 60.0-62.9
C+ = 77.0-79.9	F = 59.9 and below

Grades for the Papers will be given in percentages. All other grades will be given in points. Your final grade will be determined by totaling your points on the assignments and converting it to a percentage score.

Attendance

Attendance is expected of all students. Much of the material read in the course is difficult and the class meetings vital for understanding it. Additionally, many of the skills and concepts you are expected to acquire can only be obtained through preparing for, attending and participating in class.

If you need to arrive more than 8 minutes late to class (according to the clock in our classroom) or have to leave early, *be sure to* contact me ahead of time. Please plan to stay for the entire class unless there is a serious reason (like health, emergency, etc.).

If class is cancelled because of inclement weather, power outages, etc., any assignments due at the time of a class cancellation will be due at the start of the next class meeting. The instructor will post further information about changes to the reading schedule and assignments on OAKS, including alternative ways to complete activities.

Exams and activities cannot be made up unless there is a legitimate reason for your absence like university related activity, health issue, family emergency, job/school interview, etc.. With exams, you should be able to provide documentation for the absence. Contact me preferably before your absence or immediately after about how to make up the activity. You must be present at the time of the activity in order to receive credit for it.

Participation cannot be made up unless you have a legitimate reason for missing that day's class. To make up a day's worth of class participation, you must contact me within 3 days (72 hours) of the absence about making up the participation. I will then explain how the participation can be made up.

Computers, noise-makers and other devices of distraction

Cell phones, beepers, tablets and other electronic noise makers *must be* turned off during class and kept face down on your desk or stowed in your bag.

Generally, laptops and other information and communication technologies will not be necessary for class. If they will be, I will alert you ahead of time. Unless part of the day's activity, all computers and other such devises, including earbuds and headphones, must be put away. If any of these technologies are necessary to meet your accommodations, please let the instructor know and we will adjust this policy accordingly.

Getting in touch with me

I check my CofC e-mail address regularly and will get back to you as soon as possible after I receive your e-mail. If you have not received a response within 24 hours (including over the weekend), please resend your e-mail. If you upload to OAK a picture of a capybara to the instructor by 12:01 pm 24 August, you will receive 5 points of extra credit. I have regular offices when I will be available to meet in person. I am also happy to meet by appointment if those times don't work.

OAKS

OAKS, including Gradebook, will be used for this course throughout the semester to provide the syllabus and class materials and grades for each assignment, which will be regularly posted. You are expected to check OAKS regularly for announcements and other information.

Academic Integrity Statement

As members of the College of Charleston community, we affirm, embrace and hold ourselves accountable to the core values of integrity, academic excellence, liberal arts education, respect for the individual student, diversity, equity and inclusion, student centeredness, innovation and public mission. Congruent with these core values, the College of Charleston expects that every student and community member has a responsibility to uphold the standards of the honor code, as outlined in the Student Handbook, In pursuit of academic learning, you are expected to reference the work of other scholars, and complete your own academic work, while utilizing appropriate resources for assistance. Any acts of suspected academic dishonesty will be reported to the Office of the Dean of Students and addressed through the conduct process. Your adherence to these practices and expectations plays a vital role in fostering a campus culture that balances trust and the pursuit of knowledge while producing a strong

foundation of academic excellence at the College of Charleston. Any questions regarding these expectations can be clarified by your instructor.

Statement on use of Generative Artificial Intelligence (GAI)

Generative Artificial Intelligence (GAI) tools are not permitted for any work in this class. If you use GAI tools, your actions would be considered academically dishonest and a violation of the College of Charleston's Honor Code and Code of Conduct.

Students are bound by honor and by their enrollment at the College to abide by the specific policies of the Honor Code and the Code of Conduct, and to report any violations of the Honor System. All work submitted in this course must be your own, completed in accordance with the College's Honor Code. You may not engage in unauthorized collaboration or make use of ChatGPT or other GAI tools.

Since writing, analytical, and critical thinking skills are part of the learning outcomes of this course, all writing assignments should be prepared solely by the student and without any assistance. Questions in this regard should be shared directly with your professor. Developing strong competencies in this area will prepare you for a competitive workplace. Unless otherwise specified, the use of generative artificial intelligence (GAI), including ChatGPT and similar tools, is strictly prohibited in this course, even when appropriately referenced. In most circumstances, if there are concerns about whether GAI was used to produce your work, the instructor will contact you to discuss the work in question and determine the best way to address those concerns. The use of automated writing tools may be considered plagiarism and a violation of the CofC Honor Code.

Attendance Verification

Only students officially registered (graded or auditing) for this course may attend class. During the week following the drop/add deadline, the professor will verify student enrollments in this course. Any student appearing on the class roll but determined not to have attended the class even once will be removed, except for cases where a student is absent because of quarantine or isolation due to COVID-19.

Accommodations for Students with Disabilities

The College of Charleston is committed to providing access and inclusion for all persons with disabilities. Students with disabilities who anticipate or experience disability-related barriers in the academic setting should notify their professor, and also initiate contact with the Center for Disability Services (CDS) to move forward with the college's established accommodation process (email: snap@cofc.edu; phone: 843-953-1431; location: Lightsey Center 104). Students already connected with CDS for academic-related accommodations should share their Professor Notification Letter (PNL) with each professor as early in the semester as possible so that accommodations can be made in a timely manner. The PNL informs faculty of potential course access and accommodations that might be necessary and reasonable. It is the student's responsibility to follow this process each semester.

Inclement Weather, Pandemic or Substantial Interruption of Instruction

If in-person classes are suspended, faculty will announce to their students a detailed plan for a change in modality to ensure the continuity of learning. All students must have access to a computer equipped with a web camera, microphone, and Internet access. Resources are available to provide students with these essential tools.

Digital Accessibility

Consistent with access for all, this course uses Ally in OAKS to ensure digital content is as accessible as possible. Captions or transcripts are provided on all videos and audio recordings in the course. If you find online course materials are not meeting your needs, please reach out to me so we can remediate the content to ensure accessibility.

The Center for Student Learning csl.cofc.edu

The CSL offers academic support services for most College classes in a centralized location in the Addlestone Library. Services include drop-in and by appointment tutoring, SI (Supplemental Instruction), and academic coaching, offered at no additional charge for CofC students. Peer educators—recommended by faculty and trained by CSL staff—comprise the bulk of the staff, and as one of the largest student employers on campus, the CSL can offer on-campus employment to 130+ qualified students each year. All students are encouraged to visit, call, or email the CSL at the start of each semester to discuss which academic support services align with their current course schedule; they can also request a Personalized Resource Plan.

A Welcoming and Resilient Classroom

In this course, we will work together to create a classroom of academic belonging, balancing feeling validated, on the one hand, and being challenged, on the other. You are encouraged to embrace curiosity instead of combativeness, promoting constructive disagreement and open inquiry. Through these principles, we aim to create

an environment rich in respect for each other and viewpoint diversity of expression, thought, and values that supports personal and intellectual growth of academic inquiry. You will be exposed to new ideas and challenged beyond yourself with contrary perspectives, encouraging you to be open, engage in dialogue across differences, and defend positions with which you might not initially agree. This process of civil engagement fosters self, social, and scientific discovery, develops an understanding of diverse viewpoints, and cultivates empathy.

I will gladly honor your request to address you by the name and gender pronouns of your choice. Please advise me of this early in the semester via your college-issued email account or during office hours so that I may make the appropriate notation on my class list.

Mental & Physical Wellbeing

We take each student's mental and physical wellbeing seriously. If you find yourself experiencing physical illnesses, please reach out to student health services (843.953.5520). And if you find yourself experiencing any mental health challenges (for example, anxiety, depression, stressful life events, sleep deprivation, and/or loneliness/homesickness) please consider contacting either the Counseling Center (professional counselors at CofC Counseling Center or 843.953.5640 3rd Floor of Robert Scott Small Building) or the Students 4 Support (certified volunteers through texting "4support" to 839863, or meet with them in person 411 (4th Floor) Stern Center). Learn more about Students 4 Support on CofC's Hub. These services are there for you to help you cope with difficulties you may be experiencing and to maintain optimal physical and mental health.

Food & Housing Resources

Many CofC students report experiencing food and housing insecurity. If you are facing challenges in securing food (such as not being able to afford groceries or get sufficient food to eat every day) and housing (such as lacking a safe and stable place to live), please contact the Dean of Students for support (SALT - Student Affairs Leadership Team). Also, you can go to Student Food and Housing Insecurity to learn about food and housing assistance that is available to you. In addition, there are several resources on and off campus to help. You can visit the Cougar Pantry in the Stern Center (2nd floor), a student-run food pantry that provides dry-goods and hygiene products at no charge to any student in need. Please also consider reaching out to me if you are comfortable in doing so.

Prohibition of Discrimination

The College is committed to providing an environment free of all forms of prohibited discrimination, including sex-based harassment and violence (e.g., sexual assault, domestic and dating violence, and gender or sex-based bullying and stalking). If you have experienced discrimination or harassment, help and support are available. College employees, other than designated confidential resources, are expected to report information they receive about prohibited discrimination, including sexual harassment and sexual violence. This means that if you tell me about a situation involving sexual harassment, sexual violence, discrimination, or harassment, I am expected to share the information with the Office of Equal Opportunity Programs (EOP). You may speak to someone confidentially by contacting the Office of Victim Services at 843-953-2273, Counseling Center at 843-953-5640, or Student Health Services at 843-953-5520. You can also report any sexual misconduct, sexual harassment, or discrimination, or learn more about your options and resources, by contacting the Office of Equal Opportunity Programs at 843-953-5754.

Safe Environment

CofC is committed to providing an environment free of all forms of prohibited discrimination, including sexual harassment and violence (i.e. sexual assault, domestic and dating violence, and gender or sex-based bullying and stalking). If you have experienced discrimination or harassment, help and support are available. CofC employees, other than designated confidential resources, must report information they receive about prohibited discrimination, including sexual harassment and sexual violence. This means that if you tell me about a situation involving sexual harassment, sexual violence, discrimination, or harassment, I must share the information with the Title IX Coordinator. You may speak to someone confidentially by contacting the Office of Victim Services at 843-953-2273, Counseling Center at 843-953-5640, or Student Health Services at 843-953-5520. You can also report any sexual misconduct or discrimination, or learn more about your options and resources, by contacting the Office of Equal Opportunity Programs at 843-953-5754.

Religious Accommodation for Students

The College of Charleston community is enriched by students of many faiths that have various religious observances, practices, and beliefs. We value student rights and freedoms, including the right of each student to adhere to individual systems of religion. The College prohibits discrimination against any student because of such student's religious belief or any absence thereof.

The College acknowledges that religious practices differ from tradition to tradition, and that the demands of religious observances in some traditions may cause conflicts with student schedules. In affirming this diversity, like many other colleges and universities, the College supports the concept of "reasonable accommodation for religious observance" regarding class attendance, and the scheduling of examinations and other academic work requirements, unless the accommodation would create an undue hardship on the College. Faculty are required, as part of their responsibility to students and the College, to ascribe to this policy and to ensure its fair and full implementation.

The accommodation request imposes responsibilities and obligations on both the individual requesting the accommodation and the College. Faculty members are expected to reasonably accommodate individual religious practices. Examples of reasonable accommodations for student absences might include: rescheduling of an exam or giving a make-up exam for the student in question; altering the time of a student's presentation; allowing extra-credit assignments to substitute for missed class work or arranging for an increased flexibility in assignment dates. Regardless of any accommodation that may be granted, students are responsible for satisfying all academic objectives, requirements and prerequisites as defined by the instructor and by the College.

Land and Labor Acknowledgement

We are located on the traditional lands of the first people of Charleston: the Etiwan, Kiawah, Edisto Natchez Kusso, Santee, and Wassamassaw people (also known as Varner Town Indians). We acknowledge and honor all indigenous people who lived, labored and were faithful stewards of the land. We express our deep gratitude for the land and continued faithful stewardship to the next generations.

We also acknowledge the lives and labor of the Africans who were enslaved to build Charleston, South Carolina. On this campus and in this space, African and African-descended people used skilled labor in ornamental ironwork, historic architecture, and low country agriculture and food production. As a member of the College of Charleston community, I acknowledge the Black lives and labor that built our city and our campus.